

Duke Stone, RHP, Mississippi State

2026 Stats: 5.31 ERA/1.469 WHIP/79.2 IP/107 K/29 BB/3.69 K:BB

6-5, 235

Metrics

FB: 93.5/19 IVB/11.8 HB/-4.62 VAA/6.2 relH/7 ext/58.6 AA/41.8% zone/43% usage/2320 rpm

CB: 79.8/-9.2 IVB/-12.4 HB/-9.12 VAA/50.8 AA/29.3% zone/13.8% usage/2730 rpm

SL: 87.3/4 IVB/-5.9 HB/-7.39 VAA/49.8 AA/31.8% usage/2630 rpm

SPL: 87.3/2.3 IVB/9.7 HB/-7.59 VAA/48.8 AA/29.7% zone/22.4% usage/1190 rpm

Write-up

Stone is an imposing, physically mature right-hander whose 6-foot-5, 235-pound frame creates outstanding downhill plane and extension toward the plate. He attacks hitters with a legitimate four-pitch mix that lacks a true below-average offering, making him one of the more complete arsenals in the SEC. Watching him live against UCLA, the combination of size, extension, and a riding fastball paired with a hard slider and splitter immediately stood out. The profile has obvious professional starter traits, but the next step is refining command within the strike zone. Stone generated strikeouts at an elite rate, yet too many pitches leaked into hittable locations, contributing to a barrel rate around 20%. If he begins consistently winning on the edges rather than over the heart, there is significant upside in the profile.

The FB is the foundation of the arsenal. Sitting 93-95 while averaging 19 inches of induced vertical break from seven feet of extension, it creates difficult carry through the top of the strike zone despite only a higher than average release height. The flatter approach angle against his release height allows the ball to stay above barrels, and Stone showed confidence attacking hitters early with the pitch. The fastball failed to elite swing-and-miss numbers (8.4 SWSTR%), but the overall effectiveness was held back by inconsistent location. Too many heaters leaked middle-middle or upper-middle, allowing hitters to square up what is otherwise a premium movement profile to the tune of 10 homers and a .368 avg. When elevated above the zone or spotted gloveside, the pitch consistently played as a

bat-misser. The raw characteristics already fit a professional starter; improving command consistency could elevate it into a legitimate plus offering. 55/60+ pitch

The CB is his best pure breaker and flashes plus. Spinning north of 2,700 rpm, it combines elite depth with sharp vertical action that gives hitters a completely different look off the riding fastball. The pitch consistently generated uncomfortable takes and empty swings because hitters struggled to distinguish it early before it disappeared beneath the barrel. While the overall zone rate is modest, Stone demonstrated enough feel to land it for called strikes early in counts before expanding underneath the zone with two strikes. The 50% whiff rate and near 20% SWSTR show this feel for putaway, backing up the elite 37% putaway rate. He was also able to land it consistently to lefties for valuable called strikes. The velocity separation and movement differential make it an ideal complement to the fastball. Improving consistency landing it in competitive counts would allow it to play even more frequently as a put-away pitch. 55/60 pitch

The SL gives Stone a second distinct breaking ball and serves as his primary hard glove-side offering. Sitting in the upper 80s with above-average velocity, the slider features late depth rather than sweeping action, allowing it to play well against right-handed hitters while remaining effective against lefties when located beneath the zone. The tighter shape creates a different visual than the curveball, preventing hitters from sitting on one breaking ball profile. Stone showed confidence throwing it in multiple counts, though like the fastball it occasionally backed up over the middle of the plate, especially to lefties. Tightening command to consistently finish below the zone would significantly improve its chase and swing-and-miss profile. The shape and velocity already project well at the next level. 50/55 pitch

The SPL rounds out one of the more complete four-pitch mixes in the conference. Sitting around 87 mph with excellent velocity separation from the fastball, the pitch shows heavy late tumble with enough horizontal fade to neutralize left-handed hitters. The splitter plays particularly well off the riding fastball because hitters must honor the vertical fastball before the ball disappears beneath the barrel. Stone showed comfort throwing it in all counts, and it projects as an important weapon against opposite-handed hitters moving forward. While command can occasionally hang into the upper half,

the movement profile and velocity make it difficult for hitters to lift when located competitively as evidenced by its 58% GB rate. Continued refinement could allow the splitter to become another above-average major league offering. 55/55+ pitch